Thaddeus R. Winker

trwinker@gmail.com | (314) 477-7246 LinkedIn | GitHub

Summary

Operations and software engineering leader with more than a decade of experience guiding large, distributed technical organizations and improving service delivery in complex, regulated environments. He has led onshore and offshore engineering teams, strengthened incident response and escalation practices, redesigned support operations to eliminate repetitive work, and built high-performing Tier 2/3 groups through structured coaching, clear ownership models, and continuous improvement. His leadership includes implementing squad-based workflows, establishing 24/7 on-call rotations, developing runbooks and SOPs, enhancing cross-functional coordination, and creating executive-level reporting that improves visibility into capacity, throughput, and delivery risk. Known for elevating team autonomy, accelerating resolution times, and driving organizational change, he blends operational discipline with a people-focused approach that advances engineers, improves communication standards, and scales systems and teams in fast-growth environments.

Career History

Zelis(Formerly RedCard) — Jan 2017 – Present

Tech Stack: C# .Net, SQL, CI/CD, GIT, Azure DevOps, Full Stack

Manager, Software Engineering *(Apr 2024 – Present)*

Team Coaching & Leadership

- Led a 10+ person onshore and offshore engineering team, providing clear direction, structured coaching, and consistent performance management.
- Developed engineers through targeted growth plans, increasing ownership, autonomy, and readiness for higher-level responsibilities.
- Strengthened team culture by establishing expectations, improving communication standards, and creating predictable, supportive leadership rhythms.

Operational Improvements & Process Management

- Reorganized the team into a squad-based operating model, improving accountability, delivery flow, and cross-team coordination.
- Built and implemented a 24/7 on-call program with defined escalation paths, improving response consistency and reducing operational risk.
- Created runbooks, SOPs, and troubleshooting guides that raised technical readiness and reduced repeat incidents.
- Partnered across Infrastructure, Networking, Operations, Client Services, and Product to deliver reliable platform changes and resolve high-impact issues.
- Produced executive-recognized Jira dashboards and reporting that improved visibility into capacity, throughput, and delivery risk.
- Worked with senior leadership to assess team capacity, refine intake processes, and plan strategic operational changes.
- Led structured sprint planning cycles balancing planned work with production support, escalations, and release constraints.

AI, Automation & Developer Productivity

- Introduced AI-based error classification and remediation guidance, reducing investigation time and reliance on senior engineers.
- Redesigned support workflows using machine learning, SOP alignment, and operator training to reduce manual investigation and increase team independence.

Senior Software Engineer *(Oct 2021 – Apr 2024)*

- Provided Tier 3 support for complex user-impacting issues across a large distributed system.
- Performed administrative operations on production servers to resolve urgent issues affecting internal and external users.
- Led root-cause analysis efforts and partnered with Infrastructure and Engineering teams to remediate recurring problems.
- Met directly with clients and internal stakeholders to troubleshoot issues, explain root causes, and guide resolution plans.
- Partnered with engineering teams to remediate recurring failure patterns and improve system resilience and observability.
- Established technical standards for incident triage and escalation in a distributed services environment.

Software Engineer *(Nov 2017 – Oct 2021)*

- Partnered with business users, analysts, and management to translate requirements into software solutions for healthcare payment and financial document workflows.
- Developed systems for health insurance payment and financial document processing in a highly regulated healthcare technology environment.

Associate Software Engineer *(Jan 2017 – Nov 2017)*

- Troubleshot production issues on a large-scale distributed system.
- Reviewed peer code and tested changes.

United Educators — Feb 2016 – Dec 2016

Tech Stack: JQuery, SQL, Stingray IDE, Full Stack

Associated Software Developer *(Feb 2016 – Dec 2016)*

- Resolved production issues for UE@Work.
- Developed new features and requirements.

Elite Personnel (For United Educators) — Jun 2014 – Feb 2016

Quality Assurance Engineer *(Jun 2014 – Feb 2016)*

- Gathered requirements and tested billing and accounting functionality of UE@Work.

Now You Know Media — May 2013 – Jun 2014

Assistant Producer *(May 2013 – Jun 2014)*

- Assisted in the production of media content, including video and audio materials.
- Built a Microsoft Access royalty-payment system and provided internal technical support

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Leadership & Operational Management

- Engineering team leadership (onshore & offshore)
- Incident response, escalation management, and communication standards
- Production operations, service reliability, and support readiness
- Hiring, performance management, coaching, and career development
- Capacity planning, staffing strategy, and budget ownership
- Cross-functional coordination with Infrastructure, Networking, Operations, Client Services, and Product
- Process design, workflow optimization, and continuous improvement
- Organizational change leadership in regulated, client-sensitive environments
- Scaling teams, support models, and operational systems in fast-growth settings

Systems & Reliability Expertise

- Large scale, client facing distributed systems
- Hybrid on-prem and cloud system support and legacy system maintenance
- Production incident triage, root cause analysis, and remediation
- Operational risk management and secure system practices
- AI-enabled incident analysis, workflow automation, and ML-driven support tooling

Technical Foundations

- Windows server administration
- IIS Configuration
- FTP Server management
- Jira (JSM, Cloud, Datacenter, Confluence)
- Microsoft Teams Workflows
- Powershell, LaTex, Lua, Markdown, and other scripting languages
- C#, C++, Python, Object Oriented Programming
- SQL & relational database design
- Distributed Systems (WCF, gRPC)
- Version control (Git)
- ML.Net and applied machine learning in production workflows
- Snowflake, AWS, Azure

Education

The Catholic University of America — M.A. in Biblical Languages (Oct 2013)
Xavier University — B.A. (Honors) in Theology, Classics (May 2010)